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Delegation From Allied Gardens, San Diego
The Republic of Latvia
Commission on the Status of Women
Violence Against Indigenous Women in the Amazon

Section I

Women all over the world face violence but one place affected by this sexual violence is the Amazon. As representatives of Latvia, we do not support sexual violence against women as it is a criminal offense in Latvia. Something that we do to help women and girls who have been raped or sexually abused is we have social rehabilitation services. These rehabilitation homes have been financed by the state and have been proven to help victims.¹ Just like in Latvia, sexual abuse is illegal in most amazonian places. The women are not just fighting for the forests but also their rights as human beings. More people need to be informed about what is going on if we want to solve these problems. I say this because when people hear more about the issues these women are having, they feel empathy and try to help them. For example, when a journalist heard about what was going on in the amazon, she immediately tried to help.

Now, she is part of an alliance of women who opened a safe home for women and girls who have fled sexual violence and violence facing activists fighting for the amazon rainforests. This specific safe house lies in Ecuador and it is it's first of its kind to treat violence against women, especially indigenous women. The founder of this safe house created it because she realized that minors and deforestation groups were causing harm not just to the environment but to the people who live in the rainforest, especially the women and girls. In other words, she realized that the minors weren't only affecting the economy, but they were abusing the women and girls in the amazon because the people needed more money and food, and the minors could provide that. One important thing to note is that by asking yourself questions you can figure out how to help others. For example, these women

¹ "Latvia," European Women's Lobby, https://www.womenlobby.org/IMG/pdf/2714_latvia_lr.pdf

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asked themselves, “How can we support indigenous women,” and “How can we collectively heal?” By asking these questions, we can figure out ways to solve these problems.²

Rehabilitation homes have not only given women new and safer houses, but they have also provided legal support. Additionally, this is even more effective because it is a community of women who have all gone through the same problems. One way that these homes help abused women is by creating a support system where the women listened to what everyone had to say. As the amount of domestic violence rises, the need for houses like these, especially in the Amazon, rises. With violence rising, there are more and more attacks that lead to trauma for indigenous people.

Because some of the women are activists trying to stop minors and other people from destroying their homelands, they face more risks. One website compares information between six different indigenous women living in the Amazon and shows what types and reasons for their abuse/violence. The graph showed that 5 out of 6 of the women’s violence was caused by Personal Relationship as Resistance’s space (PR) and Female Leadership (FL). These two occurred the most often but there were thirty-six other reasons and some happened more than once.³

Victims say that it is hard to achieve justice for multiple reasons. Some of these are because of corruption or sexism but one of the most common reasons is simply because they live

² “Indigenous women battle growing Amazon violence with victim center,” Melissa Godin and Thomson Foundation, published 10 July 2022,

<https://bdnews24.com/society/indigenous-women-battle-growing-amazon-violence-with-victim-center>

³ “Kaleidoscopes of violence against indigenous women (VAIW) in Colombia: the experiences of Pan-Amazonian women,” Angela Santamaria, Daniela García, Fallon Hernández and Andrés Pardo, published April 8, 2019, <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/0966369X.2018.1518313?journalCode=cgpc20>

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too far away from proper authorities that will do something when they report sexual violence.

Sometimes, threats come from these women's communities. There is violence on all fronts of the world that women live in and we need to do something to decrease the amount of sexual violence. Six in ten women who have reported being assaulted have experienced some form of sexual violence. Additionally, of the other four women in that ten, at least two of them have experienced sexual violence, they just do not want to admit it.

Sexual assault prevention programs have been used for a long time in almost every country. These programs have mainly been focussing on what not to do but this has not shown to help. Teachers have taught both victims and the attacker about the consequences of sexual assault but as previously stated, these methods have not made a big difference in the amount of sexual and domestic violence in this world. One program that is the opposite of the one stated above is the healthy relationship approach to this problem. This approach teaches people what a healthy relationship is and how to maintain one. It helps others respect their partners and provide fewer reasons for sexual abuse, therefore, creating lower accounts of it. The relationships these programs talk about are not just dating or married ones, they are also family and business relationships because those are also different causes of violence. ⁴

⁴ "Healthy Relationship Approaches to Sexual Assault Prevention," Coreen Farris, Melissa Marie Labriola, Sierra Smucker, Thomas E. Trail, Samuel Peterson, Brandon Crosby, and Terry L. Schell, https://www.defenseculture.mil/Portals/90/Documents/A2S/Factors/SAPR/RAND_RR4241.pdf?ver=zwE7SKvN0qltidHqePTU6A%3D%3D

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Section II

Latvia has worked extremely hard to get rid of its domestic violence and protect victims of violence. Furthermore, the country is currently looking to find a way to ratify the Istanbul Convention.⁵ The Istanbul Convention was created to stop combat and domestic violence. This convention sets a standard that saves millions of girls' and women's lives. In other words, this is a group of people who create a treaty every 5 years that stop religion and gender-based violence. This treaty specifically targets violence against women and girls. This treaty sets a minimum standard for governments in Europe. These minimum standards consist of prevention, protection, and prosecution of domestic and sexual violence against women and girls. The convention also sets rules about protection and support services that every state has to follow. These rules consist of; a reasonable number of shelters, rape crisis centers, free helplines that you can reach at any hour of the day, psychological counseling, and health care for any survivors of sexual violence, forcing governments to ensure education about gender equality, healthy relationships, and sexuality. This is key legislation to ensure that if violence occurs, there is a process to help women who have experienced it. Finally, one of the most important things in this constitution is that lesbian, bisexual, transgender women, and intersex people who face or have faced hostility all over Europe are entitled to protection and all of the other things that come with this treaty too. One more thing to add to that statement is that refugees and immigrants are also protected from

⁵ “In dialogue with Latvia, Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women calls for specific gender equality legislation,” United Nations, published February 11, 2020, <https://www.ohchr.org/en/statements/2020/02/dialogue-latvia-committee-elimination-discrimination-against-women-calls>

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this constitution if the country they live in has signed this constitution. Latvia is a part of the Istanbul Convention and so are lots of other countries in Europe such as Ukraine and Germany.⁶

One important thing to know about Latvia is we have tried and mainly achieved gender equality. We have even had a woman as a president and a prime minister. On that note, Latvia has experts studying gender equality and how to achieve it. Since 2014, Latvia has worked extremely hard to create a legal framework to reduce the amount of domestic violence and protect the victims of it. By educating the people in Latvia, we have successfully created more awareness and helped people realize how wrong sexual violence is. The Criminal Procedure Law has been updated and strengthened to have much more safeguards and chances for victims to report abusers. Latvia also believes that a full understanding of women's rights is essential for the commitment to the Beijing Platform for Action. The government has focused its resources on creating gender equality, especially in areas of education, and work/labor, which is important for smart, sustainable, and inclusive growth.⁷

The Beijing Platform for Action declaration is an agenda for the empowerment of women. It is also one of the basis to analyze the situation women are in around the world and know what places are doing to support women's empowerment. The Beijing Platform for Action started in 1995 and includes over 40,000 government delegates, representatives, and experts from all over the world. This action creates the commitment of the international community and

⁶ "Here's why the Istanbul Convention Saves Lives," Amnesty International, May 7, 2021, <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2021/05/heres-why-the-istanbul-convention-saves-lives/>

⁷ "In dialogue with Latvia, Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women calls for specific gender equality legislation," United Nations, published February 11, 2020, <https://www.ohchr.org/en/statements/2020/02/dialogue-latvia-committee-elimination-discrimination-against-women-calls>

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They are trying to achieve gender equality and provide better experiences and opportunities for both women and girls.

The platform of action helps women and girls globally who have or currently are fighting for gender equality and women's rights. This law is still important today because we have not fully achieved gender equality and that is something that we are working towards. It also sets an agenda for governments, organizations, and the private sector to safeguard women's rights as humans and they make sure gender is taken into account in all policies and programs. The Beijing Platform for Action is reviewed by CSW every five years and they have taken reports every year to show how the action has been working and what has to change or be improved.⁸ As was previously stated, Latvia is now part of the Beijing Platform for Action and is working hard to have gender equality in its states.

Section III

The Delegation of Latvia has created two different solutions for this problem. Solution 1: Our first proposed solution is to create more safe houses in the Amazon for women and girls who have or are currently facing sexual or domestic violence. These houses would provide a community for these women to feel safe in hence the name and get a start at a better life. The women and girls are allowed to bring their children or siblings with them if they are also a threat to violence whether it be sexual or just domestic. These children would still get all the same

⁸ "Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action," Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia, <https://archive.unescwa.org/our-work/beijing-declaration-and-platform-action#:~:text=The%20Beijing%20Declaration%20and%20Platform,in%20support%20of%20women's%20empowerment.>

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benefits of the safe house that the women and girls get. The women and girls living in these safe houses would have access to counseling, health care, a job, and better education and legal support. We would provide these things by having counselors from other states/ countries come in and live inside our residencies and give these women 24/7 care or counseling. We would also have nurses and doctors from other countries/ states who can volunteer to leave where they currently are to help these women and girls. Each person would get paid a small amount of money per day but they would get access to healthcare, a place to live, and education for their families. A job that a victim can have before they are ready to go back to normal life is taking care of the kids in the nursery or being a teacher. We also have actual educators but in some cases, women who were abused were teachers or cared for children in their native land and want to keep doing that. We would accept any person needing assistance, even if they are LGBTQ+. In our safe houses, we have people from newborn babies to women who are in their 40s or 50s. We also take volunteers of women in the community who would like to help out and make women feel more at home. Each house will be able to have about 20-30 staff members and 40-50 victims. These houses will be all over the Amazon and they will help victims go back to their normal lives.

Our second proposed solution is to educate children more about sexual harassment, domestic violence, and healthy relationships so we can stop it at an early age. This program would be called, "Take a Stand." Take a Stand would go to schools and communities in the amazon to start and then maybe in the future around the world to explain to kids what sexual violence is and why it is a bad thing. It would also explain how to stay in a healthy relationship

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and what that is. This program is fundamental to make sure that future generations do not have sexual violence and to create gender equality for all. Take a stand would focus on the most important problems under the umbrella of sexual violence and explain to kids ages 10-18 why this happens, how it is wrong, and what they can do to stop it. The whole program will be kid friendly and will not discuss any topics that are too harsh or violent for the kid's age group. It will also be understandable so that no kids are left questioning anything about this program and if they are then, we can answer their questions. We can also give them ways if they would like to help victims like making cards with thoughtful messages in them to make the victims feel safe. With the older side of the group, we will also go over how to report being sexually harassed and that no matter what the abuser says, it is still good to report. We will also provide them with legal help if any of them were ever abused or hurt. The teachers of these lessons would understand every native language and be teachers/ friendly people so the students are not startled. The teachers will get paid a lot of money coming from the world bank and their hotel and plane tickets will also be paid for. They will also get the experience of going to these native places in the Amazon and seeing how these people live in rustic areas different from our own.

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Legal Clothing Restrictions on Women

Section I

Clothing regulations that prevent women from dressing how they prefer to instill sexist stereotypes that must be addressed. Dress codes and clothing regulations have been implemented and inferred by society and the government for hundreds of years. However, now that we are in modern times, these regulations are outdated, clearly sexist, and often xenophobic. To specify, a study in America shows that 86 percent of professionals and 80 percent of managers scrutinize that clothing choices affect the chance of promotion. Also, a study on a large North American retail chain shows that women in the workforce are 14 percent less likely to be promoted to a better position. This is definitive evidence showing the influence a woman's clothing has on her position at work, no matter the progress she has made. This clearly conveys that it is a crucial problem to address because it strips women of their right to freedom of expression and creates more conflicts than it solves. For instance, in Iran, the punishment for not wearing the hijab correctly is up to two months in prison with a fine. Recently, Masha Amini was killed in Iranian police custody for not wearing her hijab correctly, so protests have erupted causing over 400 protesters to be killed and about 18,000 arrests. There are also countries that require women to wear less clothing. For example, France has banned all burqas and niqabs. In 2004 they also excluded all headscarves, hijabs, and religious symbols from state schools and government buildings. This caused conflict with the Muslim community in France; the UN Human Rights

Committee states that a ban on face veils is inconsistent with International Law and Human Rights definitive standards, considering it discriminatory. In addition, the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights has stated that averting women from wearing a head scarf or hijab in France is against their customs and standards. In brief, the opinion of ICCP and ILHR show that dress codes that are inferred or coded in law are not up to modern standards for women's rights.

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Section II

Like many other European countries, Latvia has recognized the importance of women's rights and safety. Latvia has taken many extensive measures to ensure women's rights to get an exemplary score on the GII (Gender Inequality Index). For instance, the Constitution of the Republic of Latvia states, "all humans in Latvia are equal before the law and the courts. Human rights are being exercised without any discrimination whatsoever." Latvia does not have many clear policies that ensure their opinion on dress codes and regulations, but we can infer from the policies and information that we do have that Latvia has a strong belief in women having the right to their own clothing choices as long as it is not a safety precaution physically or culturally. For example, in 2016, Latvia implemented a legal ban on burquas and Islamic face veil coverings, even though only three women within the country were known to wear them. It was clarified later on that this ban was not put in place for public safety but instead to preserve Latvian cultural values and to give public space to individuals. This policy isn't uncommon in other European countries allied with Latvia; such as France, Denmark, and Belgium. For exemplification, France and Latvia are both participating members of the European Union and NATO. They have both implemented the ban on the burqa for various reasons such as public safety and the protection of European merit. Latvia has no other clear laws or policies that relate

to dress codes, but they do have social expectations for what the general public should wear.

Multiple sources state that business attire for Latvian women includes jackets with trousers pants or skirts. This should be unproblematic of business expectations, but in Latvia what a woman wears does state status. This causes many Latvian women to be pressured to wear gold jewelry, expensive clothing, shoes, and accessories. It is also said that many Latvian women wear strong perfumes to work to make good impressions. These are very common work standards although they could be improved.

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Section III

Latvia has been involved in helping solve women's rights for many years by increasing women's wages in underrepresented work areas and implementing the Concept Paper on Gender Equality Implementation (2001). But, there are many ways Latvia can expand its support towards women's rights. For example, Latvia can help secure funds to create refugee centers for women and children in countries that have enforced dress codes and laws that prevent women from living in safe environments. For instance, in Iranian women are forced to cover most of their bodies and wear the hijab. There are serious consequences for women who do not wear the hijab correctly, and women have died trying to protest these unjust dress codes. To further articulate my resolution, according to UNHCR's data, the most common destinations for Iranian refugees are Canada, Germany, and the United Kingdom, all of which are allies of Latvia. Giving funds to help improve and create new and more available refugee centers in these places would make it easier for the refugees to start their new life. Giving funds to this cause would help support families to get jobs, healthcare, and housing. This would also help the lack of employment that refugees and immigrants face. This would also pose an attainable solution for countries like Sudan, Saudi Arabia, Lybia, and Iraq, which also have strict and enforced dress codes for women. This possible resolution helps women in countries where religious attire is enforced, but it doesn't completely resolve the problem of dress codes. It excludes places where attire that

shows religious symbols is seen as a negative clothing choice. For example, Orthodox Jewish women often get seen by the public as too restrictive and can get shamed for their traditional way of life. This is also common with other religious groups that infer more modest clothing such as Morman, Amish, Orthodox Christian, and Muslim communities. A way that Latvia could involve itself to prevent this from happening within its own country would be to publicly advertise a plethora of minority religions that don't get positively recognized by the public. This would expose Latvian citizens to more diverse religions and ideologies, strengthening Latvia as a whole. We could get funding for advertisements and events by creating public functions, fundraisers, and fun activities that will educate and involve the public. In total, these resolutions positively affect Latvia and its allies, nourishing their relations to a further extent while helping women from across the world reach a new point of religious and expressive freedom.

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